- **When benefits and premiums start**

  The benefits in this brochure are effective January 1. If you joined this Plan during Open Season, your coverage begins on the first day of your first pay period that starts on or after January 1. **If you changed plans or plan options during Open Season and you receive care between January 1 and the effective date of coverage under your new plan or option, your claims will be processed according to the 2026 benefits of your prior plan or option.** If you have met (or pay cost-sharing that results in your meeting) the out-of-pocket maximum under the prior plan or option, you will not pay cost-sharing for services covered between January 1 and the effective date of coverage under your new plan or option. **However**, if your prior plan left the FEHB Program at the end of 2025, you are covered under that plan's 2025 benefits until the effective date of your coverage with your new plan. Annuitants' coverage and premiums begin January 1. If you joined at any other time during the year, your employing office will tell you the effective date of coverage.

  If your enrollment continues after you are no longer eligible for coverage (i.e., you have separated from Federal service) and premiums are not paid, you will be responsible for all benefits paid during the period in which premiums were not paid. You may be billed for services received directly from your provider. You may be prosecuted for fraud for knowingly using health insurance benefits for which you have not paid premiums. It is your responsibility to know when you or a family member are no longer eligible to use your health insurance coverage.

- **When you retire**

  When you retire, you can usually stay in the FEHB Program. Generally, you must have been enrolled in the FEHB Program for the last five years of your Federal service. If you do not meet this requirement, you may be eligible for other forms of coverage, such as Temporary Continuation of Coverage (TCC).

When you lose benefits

- **When FEHB coverage ends**

  You will receive an additional 31-days of coverage, for no additional premium, when:

  - Your enrollment ends, unless you cancel your enrollment; or
  - You are a family member no longer eligible for coverage.

  Any person covered under the 31-day extension of coverage who is confined in a hospital or other institution for care or treatment on the 31st day of the temporary extension is entitled to continuation of the benefits of the Plan during the continuance of the confinement but not beyond the 60th day after the end of the 31-day temporary extension.

  You may be eligible for spouse equity coverage or assistance with enrolling in a conversion policy (a non-FEHB individual policy).

- **Upon divorce**

  If you are an enrollee and your divorce or annulment is final, your ex-spouse cannot remain covered as a family member under your Self Plus One or Self and Family enrollment. You must contact us to let us know the date of the divorce or annulment and have us remove your ex-spouse. We may ask for a copy of the divorce decree as proof. In order to change enrollment type, you must contact your employing or retirement office. A change will not automatically be made.